

Shabbos Nachamu - Parshas Vaeschanan is a beloved parsha. It has two עליות for which people bid a lot of money: שמע ישראל and עשרת הדברות. One of the most famous, if not the most famous, differences between Yisro and Vaeschanan is what we say every Friday night in Lecha Dodi: זְכוֹר בְּדְבוּר אֶחָד. Only הקדוש ברוך הוא can say two things at the same time. Nobody else can. People can talk out of both sides of their mouth, להבדיל, but only הקדוש ברוך הוא can say two things at the same time.

That brings us to an interesting story, one of my favorites, brought down in Rabbi Peretz Steinberg's beautiful sefer on חומש called ספר פרי עץ חיים in the name of R' Yaakov Kamenetsky on the pasuk (5:12) שְׁמֹר וְזָכוֹר בְּדְבוּר אֶחָד. R' Yaakov once went into a חדר in ירושלים where there were little kids, and he asked them, "In Lecha Dodi it says זְכוֹר בְּדְבוּר אֶחָד. But what was actually written on the לוחות, did it say שְׁמֹר or זָכוֹר?" All the little קינדערלאך raised their hands. He went through the whole room, and they all said, "It said זָכוֹר on the לוחות" which is what you see in every shul.

One little fellow in the back said, "It said שְׁמֹר on the לוחות." R' Yaakov asked him, "How do you know that?" The boy replied, "That's what it says in the סידור." "Where?" The boy answered, "In Shabbos shachris: יִשְׁמַח מֹשֶׁה בְּמִתְּנַת חֻלְקוֹ כִּי עָבַד נֶאֱמָן קִרְאָתָּ לּוֹ כְּלִיל תַּפְאָרֶת בְּרָאשׁוֹ נָתַתָּ בְּעַמְּדוֹ לְפָנָיִךְ עַל הַר סִינַי וּשְׁנֵי לַחֹת אֲבָנִים: זְכוֹר וְזָכוֹר בְּדְבוּר אֶחָד. That the לוחות had written שְׁמֹר, not זָכוֹר. R' Yaakov said, "This boy is going to grow up to be a big חכם."

What are we saying when we say שְׁמֹר and זָכוֹר? What is the message? What is the concept? What are we trying to learn from this? Anything that is precious to us has to be guarded. We constantly think about the things that are precious to us - not our possessions, not our גשמיים, but our רוחניות: our family, our טייערע, our spouses, our parents. These are the precious things. Our תורה and our מצוות. Shabbos is one of our most prized possessions of all. We have to guard it. We have to keep it. We have to take care of it. We have to watch and look for better and newer ways to be more careful with Shabbos.

The more that we learn הלכות שבת, the more we learn how to do it right. Just a tiny example: I used to love to put scallions into my chicken soup on Friday night. Rabbi Oelbaum once told me that I'm not allowed to do that, because scallions are easily cooked - it's called קְלִי הַבִּישּׁוּל - and even though we normally say that there's no בישּׁוּל in a כְּלִי שְׁלִישִׁי, with foods that are קְלִי הַבִּישּׁוּל, like scallions, we say there can be בישּׁוּל even in a כְּלִי שְׁלִישִׁי. So I learned something; now I don't do it, and I'm being שומר שבת even more than I did before.

No matter what it is, every single little thing that we do adds up. The things we think are little down here are very big up there. And some of the things that the world thinks are big down here are nothing up there, as we well know. Let us all strive to do all of our המצוות better, and we will indeed be מקיים. שְׁמֹר וְזָכוֹר בְּדְבוּר אֶחָד.

